

Chapter 17: Dinner Gathering

Feng Yue was caught off guard and embraced completely, but fortunately Wen Zhen supported her from behind. However, it wasn't until she heard that familiar nickname that she reacted.

Feng Yue steadied herself and smiled helplessly, reaching out to give the girl a big hug: "I didn't even know when you came back."

"I just came back today! I missed you so much!" The girl hugged even tighter as she spoke, even nuzzling against Feng Yue.

"Alright, alright, you're going to strangle me to death. Loosen up a bit." Feng Yue's cheeks were a bit red, obviously from being hugged too tightly.

Yan Lin approached with a stern face and grabbed the girl by the back collar of her clothes, making her release Feng Yue: "That's enough."

Zhou Qiongqiong watched this scene with her mind already in chaos. Wasn't this supposed to be catching an affair? How did it turn into a family reunion?

Just as Zhou Qiongqiong stood there in a daze, the girl suddenly moved to her front, smiling sweetly: "Sister Qiong¹, don't you recognize me?"

Zhou Qiongqiong: ?

She frowned and carefully examined the girl in front of her. She had a cute and sweet face, with long curly eyelashes that fluttered when she blinked. Her waist-length hair was dyed pink but had faded to almost yellow, probably from not touching up the color in time. Her black roots had grown out quite a bit, making it look like pudding². She wore the most ordinary shirt and knit vest, with a pleated skirt on the bottom, looking like a high school student.

Zhou Qiongqiong carefully searched her memory and found that she might really have no recollection of such a person.

Zhou Qiongqiong looked helplessly at Feng Yue, who smiled at her: "The little devil king³ who ran away halfway through our class."

When the name "little devil king" came out, Zhou Qiongqiong was stunned for a few seconds, then a figure quickly appeared in her mind.

"Fu Sixue?!"

"Sister Qiong, you finally remembered!" Fu Sixue also came forward to hug her.

Then she turned around and complained unhappily to Feng Yue: "Little Moon, what do you mean 'ran away halfway'? I was obviously forced to go abroad, okay?"

Feng Yue quickly backed down. She didn't want to argue with the little devil king: "Alright, alright, I misspoke."

The reunion between these people might not finish anytime soon, and the two servers nearby were already completely confused. It was Wen Zhen who saw that the two were getting anxious and suggested: "Let's go into the private room first. It's not good to block the way here."

Yan Lin had originally wanted everyone to go to the private room she had reserved, but Fu Sixue, this little traitor, had already followed Zhou Qiongqiong toward the other party's private room, so she had no choice but to follow.

Fu Sixue leaned intimately against Feng Yue, murmuring: "I had A-Lin⁴ invite you out for dinner, but you said you had plans. So you were just having dinner with Sister Qiong."

Speaking of this, Feng Yue remembered that there was still Wen Zhen in the private room who wasn't familiar with everyone, so she stood up to introduce Fu Sixue and Yan Lin.

"This is Fu Sixue, mine and Qiongqiong's high school classmate who went abroad later; this is Yan Lin, my wife." When Feng Yue mentioned Yan Lin, there wasn't a trace of emotion in her voice.

"This is Wen Zhen, my friend and also Qiongqiong's senior sister."

The two groups greeted each other and sat down in the private room, but Fu Sixue seemed very interested in Wen Zhen. After greeting her, she squeezed next to her, her eyes curved in a smile, sweetly saying: "Sister Wen Zhen, you're so beautiful."

Wen Zhen had never encountered such a straightforward and bold girl before, so she was a bit stunned: "Ah, thank you, you're very cute too."

"Sit properly, don't act up." Yan Lin expressionlessly intervened to restrain Fu Sixue.

Fu Sixue stuck out her tongue and sat back next to Feng Yue.

"Since everyone knows each other now, how about we all have dinner together?" Zhou Qiongqiong asked tentatively, her gaze wandering between Feng Yue and Yan Lin.

Looking at it this way, these two people's conflict hadn't been resolved yet.

Fu Sixue was the first to agree: "That would be great, I like having dinner with beautiful sisters."

"You're the only sister here." Feng Yue complained.

But Fu Sixue's words weren't wrong. Among the five people present, not one of them wasn't beautiful. Zhou Qiongqiong naturally didn't need to be mentioned - to be the lead dancer of a dance troupe, her appearance was the kind of striking beauty that people couldn't forget. Wen Zhen was slightly older among the five, with gentle features but also a graceful beauty full of charm. Fu Sixue was charming and cute, with two dimples when she smiled. Yan Lin was like a walking refrigerator⁵, like a snow goddess growing on unreachable snowy mountains. And Feng Yue wasn't as stunning as the others at first glance, but those watery eyes were gentle enough to drown someone in them.

Getting off track, back to the private room.

Yan Lin had originally come to welcome Fu Sixue back⁶, and since she wanted to dine here together, she nodded in agreement.

Zhou Qiongqiong called over a server and started ordering. Their tastes were all quite similar - none of them could handle spicy food well.

Fu Sixue idly played with her chopsticks while listening to Zhou Qiongqiong order, until she finished and then frowned: "Aren't you ordering any spicy dishes? Little Moon likes Sichuan cuisine⁷, right?"

Zhou Qiongqiong was stunned upon hearing this. But she remembered that when Yan Lin ordered during the last class reunion dinner, all the dishes she added were sweet.

Feng Yue waved her hand: "It's fine, I'm not feeling well lately and have dietary restrictions. I can't eat spicy or stimulating foods, so this is good."

"Alright then, since you're not feeling well, let's add a nourishing soup." Fu Sixue made the final decision and had the server take the menu and leave.

Then she began asking with concern about what exactly was making Feng Yue uncomfortable.

Meanwhile, Yan Lin hadn't participated in their conversation at all. Her mind kept echoing that sentence about Feng Yue liking Sichuan cuisine.

Did Feng Yue like Sichuan cuisine?

Yan Lin sat there in a daze, her mind constantly recalling Feng Yue's taste preferences. In her previous life, during the years she was married to Feng Yue, she had never seen a single Sichuan dish on their home dining table.

Even when occasionally having dinner at Feng Yue's parents' house, the table was mostly filled with Cantonese cuisine⁸ that Yan Lin liked.

Feng Yue shouldn't like Sichuan cuisine...

No, that's not right.

Yan Lin remembered their first meal together. On the school rooftop, that overwhelming spicy and stimulating aroma came from Feng Yue's lunch box.

Feng Yue did like Sichuan cuisine. It was just because she liked Cantonese cuisine that Feng Yue also changed her taste preferences. She didn't know when, but Sichuan cuisine had completely disappeared from their lives.

How many changes had Feng Yue made for her...

Yan Lin took a deep breath, but this breath was like a knife, cutting her throat painfully, making her hands tremble involuntarily.

For the first time, Yan Lin felt a sense of defeat. She didn't even know what Feng Yue liked to eat. No wonder Feng Yue wanted to divorce her.

Could she really change Feng Yue's mind?

Fu Sixue chatted animatedly with the others, keeping the atmosphere lively, but when she caught a glimpse of her friend's expression, her face turned serious for a moment.

Then, while Zhou Qiongqiong was talking about her glorious career, she sweetly asked Yan Lin to accompany her to the bathroom.

Yan Lin, who was still lost in her own world, naturally didn't refuse and was pushed out of the private room by Fu Sixue like a walking corpse.

But the two who left the private room didn't head straight to the bathroom. Instead, they stopped at the smoking area not far from the restroom.

Fu Sixue looked at Yan Lin, who remained silent like a stuffy bottle, and sighed helplessly. She took out a pack of cigarettes from her bag and offered one to Yan Lin: "Speak up, what's going on? You asked me to come back quickly in your email. It should be related to Little Moon, right?"

Yan Lin lit the cigarette at her fingertips with Fu Sixue's lighter, and a peach scent spread around them: "Mm. She wants to divorce me."

Fu Sixue was stunned for two seconds, obviously shocked by this answer. But after a moment, she blinked and returned to normal, even letting out a nervous laugh: "I wondered why you two were like enemies today, not saying a word to each other. I thought you just had a simple argument."

"I wouldn't argue with her." Yan Lin lowered her eyelashes, as if making some kind of promise.

Fu Sixue felt a headache coming on: "Ah— I can probably guess why Little Moon wants to divorce you, but I didn't expect that after all these years, you really haven't grown at all." She slowly blew out smoke rings as she spoke.

Yan Lin frowned: "What do you mean?"

"If you don't want a divorce, you have to speak up. How is Little Moon supposed to know if you don't say anything?"

Yan Lin looked serious: "I did speak up."

"Just said you don't agree to divorce?" Fu Sixue seemed like a worm in her stomach⁹, only needing to look at her once to guess correctly.

"Then what else should I say?"

"Forget it, you completely don't understand why Little Moon wants to divorce you." Fu Sixue extinguished her cigarette. "When a married couple wants to divorce, the biggest possibility is that there's no love left, and Little Moon wants to divorce you for the same reason. She can't feel your love for her, so naturally her heart has died."

Yan Lin listened in a daze. She had never thought the problem was here: "But, but I don't know what love is, and I don't know if I like her." Fu Sixue's words seemed to open the door to a new world for Yan Lin.

Fu Sixue raised an eyebrow and shook her head with amusement: "Pfft, you don't know if you like her? This is probably the funniest joke I've heard this year!"

Fu Sixue sighed and continued: "Do you remember the hot spring incident during our middle school graduation trip? I pushed Little Moon from behind, making her fall into your arms.

Later you came to find me privately. You told me not to meddle in your affairs, and said that Feng Yue was still young, and you didn't want her to get caught up in romantic matters and be trapped by your side so early.

I asked you then, what if Feng Yue ran away when she grew up? You said you wouldn't let her run away, that you would keep her with you forever.

A-Lin, you've never been able to get interested in anything since childhood, but that was the first time I saw you show such strong possessiveness toward someone. If this doesn't count as liking for you, then I've really wasted all these years being your friend.

So, I think it's not her who's been trapped by your side. It's you who's been drowning in her captivity, gradually forgetting your original intention.

You forgot that even Feng Yue, when she doesn't get your response for too long, will sentence you to death and leave you."

Footnotes:

¹ **Sister Qiong (琼姐):** "Jie" (姐) is a respectful term meaning "big sister," used here as a friendly way to address Zhou Qiongqiong.

² **Pudding hair:** A popular term in East Asian countries referring to hair that's been dyed but the roots have grown out, creating a two-toned effect that resembles pudding.

³ **Little devil king (小魔王):** A playful nickname suggesting someone who's mischievous but endearing, like a cute little troublemaker.

⁴ **A-Lin (阿霖):** An affectionate nickname for Yan Lin, with "A-" being a common Chinese prefix for creating intimate nicknames.

⁵ **Walking refrigerator:** A humorous way to describe someone who is very cold and aloof in personality, as if they emanate coldness like a refrigerator.

⁶ **Welcome back (接风洗尘):** A traditional Chinese custom of hosting a meal to welcome someone who has returned from a long journey or absence.

⁷ **Sichuan cuisine (川菜):** One of the major Chinese regional cuisines, known for its bold flavors, particularly the use of garlic, chili peppers, and Sichuan peppercorns, often resulting in spicy and numbing sensations.

⁸ **Cantonese cuisine (粤菜):** Another major Chinese regional cuisine from Guangdong province, generally characterized by lighter flavors, fresh ingredients, and subtle seasonings - quite different from spicy Sichuan cuisine.

⁹ **Worm in her stomach (肚子里的蛔虫):** A Chinese idiom meaning someone who knows another person so well they can read their thoughts or predict their behavior perfectly.